Chloé **de Meulenaer**

chloedemeulenaer.github.io
c.de-meulenaer@lse.ac.uk

London School of Economics
Department of Economics
Ph.D. Candidate

Fields **Primary:** Public economics **Secondary:** Political economics, Behavioural economics

References

Camille Landais	**Johannes Spinnewijn**	**Daniel Reck**
LSE	LSE	University of Maryland
c.landais@lse.ac.uk	j.spinnewijn@lse.ac.uk	dreck@umd.edu

Education

MRes/PhD in Economics, London School of Economics (LSE)	2020–
MRes in Economics, Free University of Brussels (ULB), *magna cum laude, ranked 1st*	2016–2018
B.A. Economics, Free University of Brussels (ULB), *magna cum laude, ranked 1st*	2013–2016
B.A. Political Science, Free University of Brussels (ULB), *magna cum laude, ranked 1st*	2013–2016

Job market paper

What do reforms do? A unified analysis of support for economic policies

When people disagree on economic policy, is it because they differ in their values, or in what they think those policies do? I measure support for 29 economic reforms in a large survey, along with beliefs about their incidence, impact on the budget and impact on the macroeconomy. Participants favour reforms that they believe benefit them and minimum wage workers; however the strongest predictor of support is the reform's perceived impact on economic growth. These policy impact beliefs explain more variation in support than a range of variables shown to robustly predict demand for redistribution, such as ideology or zero-sum thinking. Policy impact beliefs shed light on both between-group and between-policy differences in support: half of the explained partisan gap is due to differences in policy impact beliefs—left- and right-wing participants have a similar mapping of beliefs to support, except for the greater weight put by left-wing individuals on the wellbeing of welfare recipients. Differences in policy impact beliefs also account for most of the explained preference for predistributive reforms over redistributive ones. I find evidence of biases in those beliefs: compared to the economic literature, participants systematically underestimate the positive effects of expansionary reforms.

Working papers

Equity or externalities: The redistributive debates in Norway and the United States

with Morten Nyborg Støstad and Max Lobeck

We use natural language processing to classify all redistributive speeches in the U.S. Congress and Norwegian parliament from 2015 to 2022. The Norwegian redistributive debate is markedly more pro-redistribution than the U.S. debate. While American legislators invoke fairness to argue for redistribution and efficiency to argue against it, the Norwegian debate does not align with the traditional equity-efficiency divide. Norwegian legislators often argue that inequality itself has socially inefficient consequences, such as lower trust, more crime, or weaker productivity (inequality externalities). In both settings, externality-based arguments are more likely to appeal to logic and consensus, while fairness arguments express more anger and compassion. In a U.S. survey experiment, fairness arguments induce more outrage but are not more convincing on average. Our results document two distinct ways to argue for redistribution, and suggest that the classic equity-efficiency dichotomy could be less universal than often assumed.

Attitudes towards the inheritance tax and demand for redistribution

This project uses new survey data from France to investigate the relative unpopularity of the inheritance tax. The tax is perceived as a tax on hard working individuals rather than on the wealthy: eliciting the perceived fairness of the inheritance tax, or of a tax "on the inheritance of hard working parents" yields similar results. Self-interest and knowledge of the tax explain little variation in support. Instead, equity and efficiency concerns, and most of all, beliefs about the effect of taxes on equity and efficiency, play a much larger role. Support for the inheritance tax is not immutable: a quote highlighting the unequal distribution of inherited wealth significantly increases support; while a quote stating that the tax is an unfair tax on a lifetime of hard work backfires on the (minority) of individuals who do not fully agree with it, increasing their support for the inheritance tax. Those asymmetrical effects suggest that challenging dominant narratives can be effective to shift opinions, even on a topic as polarised as the inheritance tax.

Work in progress

Unequal access, unequal gains? How choice environments shape decision quality
with Ben Handel, Jon Kolstad, and Johannes Spinnewijn

When policies rely on individual choice, who reaps the gains? We study how choice environments shape the quality of health insurance choices in the Netherlands. Individuals choose a deductible annually: many pick a low deductible, despite substantial potential savings from a higher one. We establish that workplaces, neighbourhoods and insurance providers causally affect these choices. The effects are substantial even in contexts that do not directly involve insurance decisions: moving to a firm or neighbourhood where high-deductible take-up is 10 percentage points higher increases individual take-up by approximately 1.5 percentage points. Across all three environments, effects are concentrated among predictably healthy individuals, who end up making better decisions as a result. More educated individuals both encounter better environments and respond more strongly to them, contributing to the education gap in choice quality. Our simulations attribute 39% to 78% of the education gap in choice quality to these environmental effects, driven primarily by differences in responsiveness.

Global health inequality: Cross-country comparisons using admin data
International project led by Raj Chetty and Maria Polyakova

Presentations

IIPF annual congress (Lisbon), EEA annual conference (Dublin), LSE Work in progress seminar (London), III Smoothie seminar (London)	2026
PSE Lunch seminar (Paris), LSE Work in progress seminar (London), NHH seminar (Bergen)	2025
PSE Lunch seminar (Paris), LSE Work in progress seminar (London), IIPF Annual Congress (Prague)	2024
LSE Work in progress seminar (London), MannheimTax (Mannheim), National Tax Association Annual Conference (Denver)	2023

Refereeing

Journal of Public Economics; Economica

Grants and awards

Programme for Cohesive Capitalism grant (GBP 5,000)	2025
Cepremap grant (EUR 5,000)	2025
Morishima fund travel grant (GBP 700)	2025
Class Teacher Award — Highly Commended	2022
Economic and Social Research Council Doctoral Studentship	2020–2025
Finalist, *"My master's thesis in 180 seconds"*	2019
Kirschen prize, for a particularly innovative and topical master's thesis in economics (EUR 1,250)	2018

Teaching

EC270 Public finance: Designing effective public policy (Summer school), LSE (Lecturers: Kate Smith, Pasquale Schiraldi)	2026
EC325 Public Economics, LSE (Lecturers: Camille Landais, Kate Smith)	2024–2026
EC1A3 Microeconomics I, LSE (Lecturer: Ronny Razin)	2021–2026
EC1A1 Microeconomics I, LSE (Lecturer: Dimitra Petropoulou)	2021–2023
ECONS1001 Microeconomics I, ULB (Lecturers: Julien Ravet, Renaud Foucart)	2016–2018
MATHS101 Mathematics I, ULB (Lecturer: Marjorie Gassner)	2015–2018
ECONS102 Macroeconomics I, ULB (Lecturer: Pierre-Guillaume Méon)	2015–2018

Work experience

LSE, pre-doctoral research assistant, Johannes Spinnewijn	2019–2020
Bruegel, Intern	2018–2019

Other

Citizenship: Belgian
Languages: French (native), English (fluent), Italian (fluent)